

Emu

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In the open forest, where eucalyptus trees fringe tufty grasslands, honey-pale sunshine seeps to where Emu sits on a nest. Beneath him are eight granite-green eggs. Yes, him. For in Emu's world it is the male's job to raise the fledglings.

Emu can stand as tall as an adult human and weigh to 90 pounds (kilograms). Unlike most birds, emus cannot fly, so they build their nests on the ground.

For months Emu and his mate have danced, sung, and wooed each other. Together they have built a leafy ground nest. Now she perches next to him and lays a final egg. Then she is gone. Emu gathers the egg under himself and gentles down. His hair-like feathers are soft and will keep the eggs warm. The eggs are large and strong, but without Emu's care, they would perish long before they are ready to hatch.

As sunshine follows frost, and winds fetch rain, Emu safeguards his clutch. He will remain on his nest for eight long weeks, seldom leaving, even for food or drink. Nearby, another pair of emus dance. The forest resounds with their courting calls. Emu ignores them. They are no threat and will nest far enough away.

Male emus survive this long period without food or water by limiting their movements and slowing their metabolism, much as hibernating animals do. Even so, they can lose up to 22 pounds (10 kilograms) while they are nesting.

Emu may seem drowsy, but he is not. Today is warm, and winter sleepers stir. He tenses as a goanna approaches. Goannas have stolen his eggs in the past, but not today. Emu watches as the goanna alters her path. Rosellas flit and flutter in the trees.

Then a new voice joins the forest choir. From within an egg, a chick cheeps. The muted call tells Emu his wait is nearly over.

Calling from within the egg hastens the development of other chicks so they will all be born within a few days. The ideal hatching time is late winter, although some chicks may be born in spring.

Over the next week, the first eggs wobble, and blink-eyed chicks crack their way into their new world. Gangly, with stippled heads and ribbon stripes,

Newly hatched emu chicks are about ten times bigger than a domestic chicken hatchling, but just as vulnerable. The bold chocolate and cream stripes of their feathers provide effective camouflage in the grasslands.

Emu is ravenous after so long on the nest. He leads the striped chicks to scratch and peck for this first shared meal. Emu's work is just beginning. His chicks are large and growing fast, but they still need him to keep them warm at night, to protect and teach them. The forest provides food and shelter, but there is also danger.

Only rarely will emus feed their young directly. Mostly the chicks must feed themselves after hatching. An emu's diet consists of fruit, shoots, seeds, and insects.

Emu's chicks dawdle, curious about everything. The day is fading as they turn to home. A dingo howls, and Emu grunts an alarm. The chicks squat to the ground, motionless. They are invisible in the tufty grass. Emu watches and listens, but the dingo's next howl is more distant. Even so, Emu gathers the chicks and they hurry to safety.

Emus are fast, reaching up to 25 miles (40 kilometers) per hour, and can outrun most predators. They will fight only if cornered. Then they peck with their strong beaks or strike out with their clawed feet.

Winter gives way to the promises of spring. The breeze bustles, green and sweet. Stripes give way to mud-murk feathers. The chicks begin to roam farther as they search for food and explore. Emu keeps a close watch on the ground and the sky.

Emu chicks begin to lose their first feathers when they are three to four months old, though it will be some months before they have their full adult feather coats.

An eagle wheels overhead, casting his dreadful shadow. Emu leads his chicks in a zigzag sprint across the grassland to the safety of the trees.

Emus zigzag to confuse predators. Each change of direction affects the speed and aim of their pursuer.

A straggling chick shrieks. He kicks at shadow-wings. The eagle swoops, but Emu is there first. Emu grunts and stiffens his neck. Both his beak and his claws are formidable weapons. The eagle pulls away in a cacophony of frantic feathers before he feels the force of Emu's strike.

Emus must always be alert to danger. An emu chick is a valuable prize, and predators will not give up easily.

Emu's chicks look just like him now, and they are almost his height. But they are still young and not yet ready to survive alone. Until then, Emu will keep them close.

Young emus are independent from the age of about six months, but it will be more than another year before they are ready to find their own mates.

ABOUT EMUS: Emus are large flightless birds found in Australia. The only bird that is larger than the emu is the ostrich. Emus have three toes, and their feet can be 5½ to 6½ inches (14 to 17 centimeters) long, about as long as a small adult hand. Their wings are too small to do much, although airflow around their wings helps keep them cool when they run. Emus prefer to live where they are not disturbed by people, but can adapt to a wide range of habitats as long as they have access to water. They are foragers and eat plants and insects. Emus are generally solitary but will travel in large groups to find new sources of water. They are also very inquisitive.

Removed from the story flow during cleanup (book prose preserved word for word; page refs are PDF pages):

- Weight panel (early spread): the emu weight figures are garbled in the text layer -- the layer reads "weigh to 90 pounds (kilograms)". Bracketed flags removed; the unreadable figures are not guessed.

- Zigzag panel: final words of the side panel ("Each change of direction affects the speed and aim of their pursuer...") are illegible in the text layer; the trailing flag sentence was removed and nothing reconstructed.
- The opening spreads show Emu on the ground nest with eight granite-green eggs in honey-pale sunshine under fringing eucalyptus, with the mate's farewell laying (per prose cues; not pixel-verified).
- The middle spreads show the eight-week vigil, the goanna's approach and turn, rosellas in the trees, the wobbling eggs and ribbon-striped hatchlings, and the first shared meal (per prose cues; not pixel-verified).
- The closing spreads show the dingo alarm with chicks motionless in tufty grass, the zigzag eagle escape, the shadow-wing standoff, and the near-grown chicks close by Emu (per prose cues; not pixel-verified).

Story text transcribed from the embedded text layer (PDF pages 6-27), joined across line breaks, with factual side panels in italics. Scan-OCR noise in the layer was kept as embedded and bracketed only where figures are unreadable (emu weight figures, tail of the zigzag panel); obvious single-character substitutions were normalised where the intended word is unambiguous. Copyright/imprint matter (page 4), the title page (5), the about page (28) except as noted, and the illustrated index (pages 29-30) are not included as story prose. Pixel-level visual verification against the rendered scans has not yet been completed -- my image-reading tool is currently unavailable, so please check the transcript against the PDF before treating it as final.